

## CASTE

We may recall that the term caste is derived from the Portuguese word "casta", used to describe the Indian society's structure.

So why exactly do we have to study caste? Isn't village a sufficient unit for analysis?

Not quite, villages no longer a self evident categorization due to  
i) migration ii) Urbanization iii) Globalization changing the very structure of villages.

→ Additionally it helps us look at humans on a social level and see the differences between different groups & the existing hierarchy.

So are difference and hierarchy different?

→ Differentiability of two objects brings in difference. E.g. different sounds of different alphabets, so it is a difference in attributes.

→ Hierarchy deals with difference or in attributes and its evaluation so as to determine its rung/position when placed vertically with others.

→ The evaluative category matters as it can change the hierarchy. It is the external evaluative categories that can form the basis of the hierarchy as inherent attributes can't be ranked. E.g. A person's JEE Rank is not inherent to a person, it is a score a person got in an exam.

In totality, all hierarchies are differences, but all differences are not hierarchies.

Wasn't caste just a division of labour then?

Though the functionalist approach, lacking the view of conflict would suggest Caste to be a division of labour,

'Caste system is not merely a division of labours. It is

It is a division of labourers.'

- B.R. Ambedkar

it is not quite so as the differences built a hierarchy, the basis of the caste system.

→ Though the nature of the caste system has changed with time, with untouchability being banned in 1950, it still continues.



Different things take up different rungs on the ladder of hierarchy based on their utility / symbolism.

eg. Sex doesn't make a hierarchy between different kinds, Patriarchy does.

→ Race talks about difference, white association with power forms a hierarchy

→ A similar argument can be extended to language.

English v/s Vernacular languages

Almost omnipresent

so more utile currently:

languages without an army  
(of users)

6.5. Lyhurgei's features of caste as a static system

- i) Segmental division of society → i.e. restricted social intercourse
- ii) Hierarchy of castes
- iii) Restrictions on breeding & social intercourse
- iv) Civil & Religious disability. → Restrictions on use of gold etc.
- v) Lack of unrestricted choice of occupation
- vi) Restrictions on marriage

What is the internal logic behind the caste system?

→ French Sociologist & Structuralist Louis Dumont, in his book *Homo Hierarchicus* talked about purity & impurity and contagion associated with diff. social groups

→ This idea of purity <sup>or pollution</sup> led to untouchability, endogamous marriages & refusal of food cooked by members of lower caste.

→ ~~Access~~ control on access to food & women, as ~~a~~ thought of carriers of impurity. (In can this belonged to a lower caste)



↑ Pure (Higher Caste)

A

B

C

↓ Pollution (Lower Caste)

\* All prefer endogamous / hypergamous marriage,

\* Food Prepared by A can be consumed by B & C, as member of caste A considered more pure.

\* Food prepared by C not acceptable to groups A and B.

\* Lower Caste members may be victims of untouchability & may not have access to religious places like temples, own gold ornaments etc.